

"MY 6-YEAR-OLD REALLY MISSED ATTENDING PHYSICAL SCHOOL WHERE SHE HAD THE CHANCE TO PLAY AND MAKE FRIENDS"

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And it was not just Covid anxiety, but also their parents' fears and insecurities children had to deal with. "The parents' anxieties got transferred to the children—loss of jobs or incomes, long WFH hours, erratic routines, domestic violence," says Chandana Bakshi, a mental health consultant at SWAYAM, a charitable public trust that works for a violence-free, gender-equal and women-empowered society.

While some children battled loneliness, others resented the helicopter parenting of WFH couples. "Children who earlier had breathing space between classes, conversations with friends in school, had hypervigilant parents monitoring every activity of theirs, whether on WhatsApp, Facebook or chat," says Bakshi. Dr Chaddha, though, finds nothing wrong in parents monitoring their children's online activities. "Especially as they were in front of a screen for a longer time due to schools being closed," she says. "A line here or an image there can cause deep stress in young minds."

Data by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) revealed that there was a 21 per cent increase in suicides by students (classified as children between four and 17 years of age) in 2020 over the previous year. An estimated 12,526 students committed suicide, with Odisha recording a 287 per cent increase over the previous year. The helplines run by the NGO Roshni in Delhi, which counsels students having suicidal thoughts, reported a spike of 26 per cent in calls from under 20-year-olds in 2020 from the year before.

Aware of the growing instances of mental stress, some educational institutes opened emergency helplines. "We started a 24x7 helpline to counsel students as instances of domestic violence started going up," says Ghosh. Domestic disruption had a direct impact on the lives of students and consequently their studies. Earlier, school would offer a means of release, the six hours spent there allowing an opportunity to share their problems with friends. The broody isolation during Covid manifested in cognitive failure, physical and mental illness.

Life after Covid

Now, as life returns to normal, with the majority of the population doubly vaccinated and schools reopening, will it also mean closing the door on the problems associated with Covid? The lockdown allowed children to